

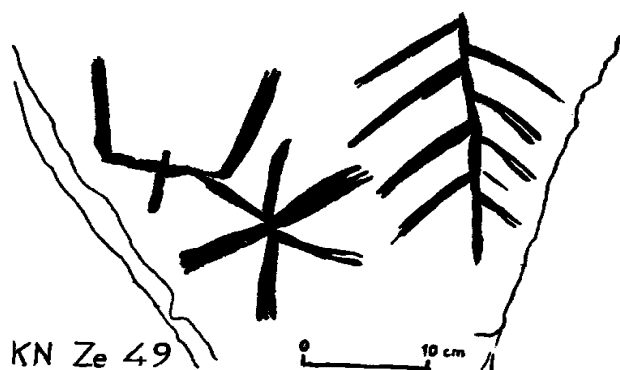


Figure 1 (after Hood)

such as the Double-Axe, Trident, Star and Branch, suggest that these inscriptions may have had a phylactic role in the Palaces. This would be understandable in a land prone to earthquakes.

In this context a possible Indo-European root presents itself. Is it possible to see an etymological link between Latin *custōs* and this Minoan word, in the sense of “custodian” of the Palace?

One might argue that Latin *custōs* and *scutum* derive from **(s)qeu-* and are cognate with Sanskrit *koṣṭha-* meaning a place for keeping provisions or an enclosing wall, and with Greek *κεύθω* meaning “to hide”¹⁰. The root meaning of **(s)qeu-* in all major branches of the Indo-European family of languages was “to cover” and/or “protect”, and this may also be the general meaning of these inscriptions from Knossos and Malia.

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A POSSIBLE READING OF LINEAR A PH Zb 4

The inscription on a pithos from the Palace of Phaistos (PH Zb 4), dated to the 16th century B.C. and now in Heraklion Museum, can be read SI-MA I-JA-TE¹ (GORILA 4 [1982] p. 93 and Fig. 1). I-JA-TE is also found on the

¹⁰ See C. D. Buck, *A Dictionary of Selected Synonyms in the Principal Indo-European Languages*, 1949, and P. Chantraine, *Dictionnaire étymologique de la langue grecque*, 1990, s. v. *κεύθω*. Doubts are expressed by J. Pokorny, *Indogermanisches etymologisches Wörterbuch*, 1959, 953 (“unsicher lat. *custōs*”) and A. Ernout – A. Meillet, *Dictionnaire étymologique de la langue latine*, 1967, s. v. *custōs*.

¹ See J.-P. Olivier, “Le ‘Lire’ Le Linéaire A?”, in *Le Monde Grec*, 1975, 441–449; L. Godart, “Du Linéaire A au Linéaire B”, in *Hommages à Henri van Effenterre*, 1984, 121–128; and Y. Duboux, “Le Linéaire A: Problèmes de Déchiffrement”, in *BCILL* 49, 1989, 59–119. In 1975, Olivier was able to demonstrate that 10 homomorphic AB signs (DA, I, JA, KI, PI, RI, RO, TA, TE, and SU) could be identified with certainty as having the same value in both scripts, so there can be no doubt about either the epigraphic or phonetic reading of I-JA-TE on PH Zb 4.